

Assignment of GE (Public Administration)

☐ **Topic: Misuse of Social Media**

College:-

Class:-

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Subject:- Public Administration

Name:- _____

— Guided by

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Introduction to Social Media

01 — The Double-Edged Sword

Social media platforms such as WhatsApp, Facebook, Instagram, X (Twitter), and YouTube have revolutionised communication. They connect billions of people instantly, enable free expression, and give governments a direct channel to citizens. However, the same power — speed, reach, and anonymity — is increasingly being misused.

- ▶ 5.4 Billion internet users worldwide; India has 900M+ users
- ▶ 750M+ Indians actively use social media platforms
- ▶ Average person spends 6.5+ hours online every day
- ▶ Information now spreads faster than verification — a core cause of misuse

“Social media misuse refers to the deliberate or negligent use of digital platforms to spread false information, harm individuals, invade privacy, defame, or manipulate public opinion.”

Connect

Inform

Empower

But also Misuse

What is Misuse of Social Media?

02 — Forms of Misuse

- ▶ Fake News: Deliberately spreading false or misleading information
- ▶ Cyberbullying: Harassment, trolling, body-shaming, threats online
- ▶ Identity Theft: Fake profiles, impersonation, financial fraud
- ▶ Privacy Violation: Leaking personal data, photos, doxxing
- ▶ Hate Speech: Content promoting enmity between communities
- ▶ Addiction & Time Waste: Excessive screen time harming studies and health
- ▶ Radicalisation & Recruitment: Terror outfits misusing platforms
- ▶ Manipulation: Paid trolls, bots, and fake followers shaping opinion
- ▶ Cyber Fraud: Phishing links, investment scams, job scams via social media

Deliberate

Intentional harm,
fraud, propaganda

Negligent

Forwarding fake news
without checking

Exploitative

Targeting children,
elderly, the vulnerable

Fake News & Misinformation

03 — The Most Widespread Misuse

- ▶ False rumours spread 6x faster than true news on social media
- ▶ Deepfakes — AI-generated fake videos of leaders and celebrities
- ▶ Health misinformation (e.g., fake cures during COVID-19)
- ▶ Communal rumours triggering riots and mob lynchings
- ▶ Political propaganda and manipulated media during elections



Why it spreads:

- ▶ Emotional & shocking content gets more likes and shares
- ▶ Algorithms reward engagement, not truth
- ▶ Many users forward messages without verification

Rule of thumb: Pause → Verify → Only then Share.

Cyberbullying & Online Harassment

04 — Harm Hidden Behind Screens



- ▶ Trolling, abusive comments, and hate messages
- ▶ Body-shaming and character assassination
- ▶ Threats, blackmail, and morphing of photos
- ▶ Exclusion from online groups and social isolation
- ▶ Victims: often students, women, and minorities

Effects: anxiety, depression, poor academic performance, and in extreme cases self-harm. Studies report 1 in 3 Indian students experience cyberbullying in some form.

What can a victim do?

1. Don't Reply

Never engage with trolls

2. Block & Report

Use platform tools

3. Save Evidence

Screenshots as proof

4. Report

Cybercrime.gov.in / 1930 helpline

Privacy & Security Misuse

05 — Your Data, Their Weapon



- ▶ Fake profiles & impersonation for fraud
- ▶ Data mining by apps and advertisers
- ▶ Doxxing — publishing private information publicly
- ▶ Phishing links stealing passwords and OTPs
- ▶ Stalking & monitoring through location tags

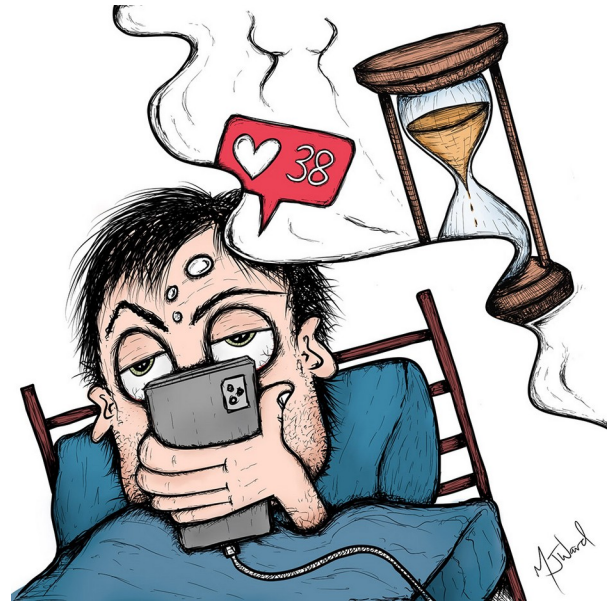
How to protect yourself:

- ▶ Use strong, unique passwords + two-factor authentication (2FA)
- ▶ Review privacy settings on every platform regularly
- ▶ Never share OTPs, bank details, or personal documents online
- ▶ Avoid third-party quiz apps and suspicious links
- ▶ Don't accept friend requests from unknown people

Addiction & Health Effects

06 — The Silent Misuse

- ▶ Dopamine-driven design: likes, shares, and infinite scroll keep users hooked
- ▶ Average teenager checks their phone 100+ times a day
- ▶ Sleep disorders, anxiety, and reduced attention span
- ▶ Poor academic performance and reduced physical activity
- ▶ “Fear of Missing Out” (FOMO) and constant comparison culture



6.5 hrs

Avg. daily screen time

100+

Phone checks per day

1 in 4

Teens showing addictive
usage

Falling

Focus, sleep & grades

Balance is key: use social media as a tool — do not let it use you.

Legal Framework in India

07 — Laws Against Social Media Misuse

IT Act, 2000 (amended 2008)	Primary law covering cybercrimes: hacking, identity theft, fake news, obscene content
Section 66C IT Act	Identity theft — punishment up to 3 years imprisonment
Section 67 IT Act	Publishing obscene material in electronic form
Section 79 IT Act	Intermediary liability — platforms must remove unlawful content
IPC Section 499–500	Criminal defamation — punishable up to 2 years
IPC Section 153A	Promoting enmity between groups — communal hate speech
DPDP Act, 2023	Digital Personal Data Protection — safeguards citizens' data privacy
IT Rules, 2021	Obligations of social media intermediaries; grievance appellate committee

Also: Cybercrime portal (cybercrime.gov.in) and National Helpline 1930 for reporting online fraud.

Impact on Governance & Society

08 — Why It Matters for Public Administration

- ▶ Law & Order: Rumours trigger mob violence and communal tension
- ▶ Elections: Fake news, bots, and paid trolls distort democratic choice
- ▶ Public Health: Vaccine hesitancy caused by misinformation
- ▶ Economy: Online scams and financial fraud erode trust in digital payments
- ▶ Administration: Officials spend resources countering viral falsehoods

Effect on Governance:

Trust Deficit

Citizens doubt authentic government information

Crisis Amplification

Panic spreads faster than official response

Policy Challenges

Regulation must balance free speech & control

Surveillance Debate

Security vs. privacy of citizens

For administrators, social media is now a public-order and communication challenge.

Case Studies

09 — Real Incidents from India

Mob Lynchings (2018)

Rumours of child kidnappers spread on WhatsApp led to multiple lynchings across Maharashtra, Karnataka & Jharkhand. WhatsApp later limited message forwarding.

COVID-19 Misinformation (2020)

Fake cures, false death counts, and vaccine rumours went viral, forcing the government to run dedicated fact-check campaigns.

Deepfake of a Politician (2024)

AI-generated audio/video clips of a chief minister went viral before elections, showing how deepfakes threaten electoral integrity.

Bois Locker Room (2020)

An Instagram group of Delhi schoolboys sharing morphed photos of girls sparked national outrage on online harassment of minors.

Celebrity Impersonation Scam

Fraudsters created fake social media profiles of celebrities promising gifts and investments, cheating fans of crores of rupees.

Positive Response: PIB Fact Check

Government's Press Information Bureau runs a fact-check unit and 'FAKE' labels on viral false claims — a governance solution to misuse.

Prevention & Way Forward

10 — Solutions at Every Level

Individual

- ▶ Verify before sharing anything
- ▶ Strong passwords + 2FA
- ▶ Limit screen time; digital detox
- ▶ Report, don't forward, harmful content

Society

- ▶ Digital literacy in schools & colleges
- ▶ Parents guide children's online activity
- ▶ NGOs run awareness campaigns
- ▶ Respectful online culture

Government

- ▶ Enforce IT Act & IT Rules strictly
- ▶ Fast-track cybercrime courts
- ▶ Promote fact-checking units (PIB)
- ▶ Balance regulation with free speech

Emerging Solutions:

AI-based fake news detection • Platform content moderation • Blockchain verification of media • Bhashini & regional-language awareness tools to reach rural users.

Conclusion & References

11 — End of Assignment

Social media is a powerful tool for communication, governance, and participation — but its misuse through fake news, cyberbullying, fraud, privacy invasion, and addiction threatens individuals, society, and democracy itself. For public administration, the challenge is to ensure safe and responsible digital spaces without curbing free expression. The solution lies in digital literacy, strong law enforcement, responsible platform design, and most importantly, responsible users. Technology is a tool; how we use it decides whether it builds or breaks society.

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